



Change Management and AI Adoption in Higher Education

**Solvay Brussels School
of Economics and Management**



Understanding Change in Digital Transformation

Day 1 Program

Morning – Understanding Change in Digital Transformation (J. Parisse)

09:00–10:30	Introduction to the seminar and strategic challenges of digital transformation in higher education • Global and regional trends • Specificities of the Vietnamese institutional context • Tensions between policy-driven change and operational realities
10:30–10:45	Coffee break
10:45–12:15	Foundations of Change Management • Lewin model: Unfreeze – Change – Refreeze • Kotter’s 8-step model • Institutional vs cultural change • Case introduction: Saigon Tech University
12:15–13:45	Lunch

Afternoon – AI Adoption: Frameworks and Institutional Diagnosis (D. Legrain)

13:45–15:00	• Conceptual input: Rogers’ Diffusion of Innovations applied to GenAI — perceived complexity as the dominant barrier (Springer, 2025) • Five profiles of non-adopters: from “not ready” to identity tension (Springer, 2025) • AI capabilities demonstration and individual maturity self-assessment: 5-dimension institutional framework (Frontiers, 2025)
15:00–15:15	Coffee break
15:15–16:00	Group workshop: institutional AI diagnostic and collective mapping

Leading Change in the Digital Age

From Strategy to Reality.

Introduction



THE NEW GENERATION OF ENTREPRENEURS NEEDS NEW COMPETENCIES

Why digital transformation matters

- **Digital transformation has become an inevitable trend and a strategic choice.**

Phạm Minh Chính

Prime Minister of Viet Nam

July 2024

Source: Ministry of Information and Communications portal

Who digital change is for

- **Digital transformation must be inclusive and truly benefit all citizens and enterprises.**

Phạm Minh Chính

Prime Minister of Viet Nam

July 2024

Source: Ministry of Information and Communications portal

The national development perspective

- **Sci-tech, innovation and digital transformation must become the core drivers of new growth model.**

Tô Lâm

General Secretary of the Communist Party of Viet Nam

March 2026

Source: Government News portal

The management dimension

- **Digital transformation is not just about technology; it is a shift in management thinking.**

Hoàng Việt Anh

Chairman, FPT Digital

December 2024

Source: FPT Digital

The human challenge of transformation

- **The key is to demonstrate patience, resilience and intelligence.**

Nguyễn Hòa Bình

Permanent Deputy Prime Minister of Viet Nam

November 2024

Source: Ministry of Information and Communications portal

Learning Objectives

- Understand why we change (Global & Regional trends).
- Identify the "Gap" between policy and daily work in Vietnam.
- Learn 2 practical models to lead your teams.
- Prepare for next workshops.

Global Trends: The "Digital First" World

- **Trend:** Data-Driven Decisions. We use data to help students succeed.
- **Trend:** AI Revolution. AI is changing how we write, research, and work.
- **Example:** Universities using "Chatbots" to answer student questions 24/7.

Regional Trends: Southeast Asia (ASEAN)

- **Focus:** Mobile-First. Most students use smartphones, not PCs.
- **Focus:** Skills over Degrees. Companies want digital skills (coding, data analysis).
- **Example:** Flexible "Micro-courses" in Singapore and Malaysia that students can take while working.

Why Digital Transformation is Hard

- It is **not** about buying computers.
- It is about changing **processes** (how we work).
- It is about changing **mindsets** (how we think).
- **Example:** Buying a new \$1M software is easy; getting 200 professors to use it every day is the hard part.

Vietnam Context: National Goals

- **Policy:** Decree 749 (National Digital Transformation Program).
- **Goal:** Vietnam wants to be a top digital nation by 2030.
- **The University Role:** You are the "engine" of this change. You train the future workers and leaders.

Vietnam Context: The "Digital Native" Student

- Vietnamese students are very young and connected.
- They expect fast, digital services (online registration, digital libraries).
- **The Challenge:** If the university is too slow/manual, students will be disappointed.

The Tension: Policy vs. Reality

- **Policy (Top):** "Go Digital! Be Innovative!"
- **Reality (Ground):** Lack of budget, old servers, and staff who are afraid to make mistakes.

Example: A Dean wants "Paperless Office," but the law still requires a physical stamp (red seal) on every document.

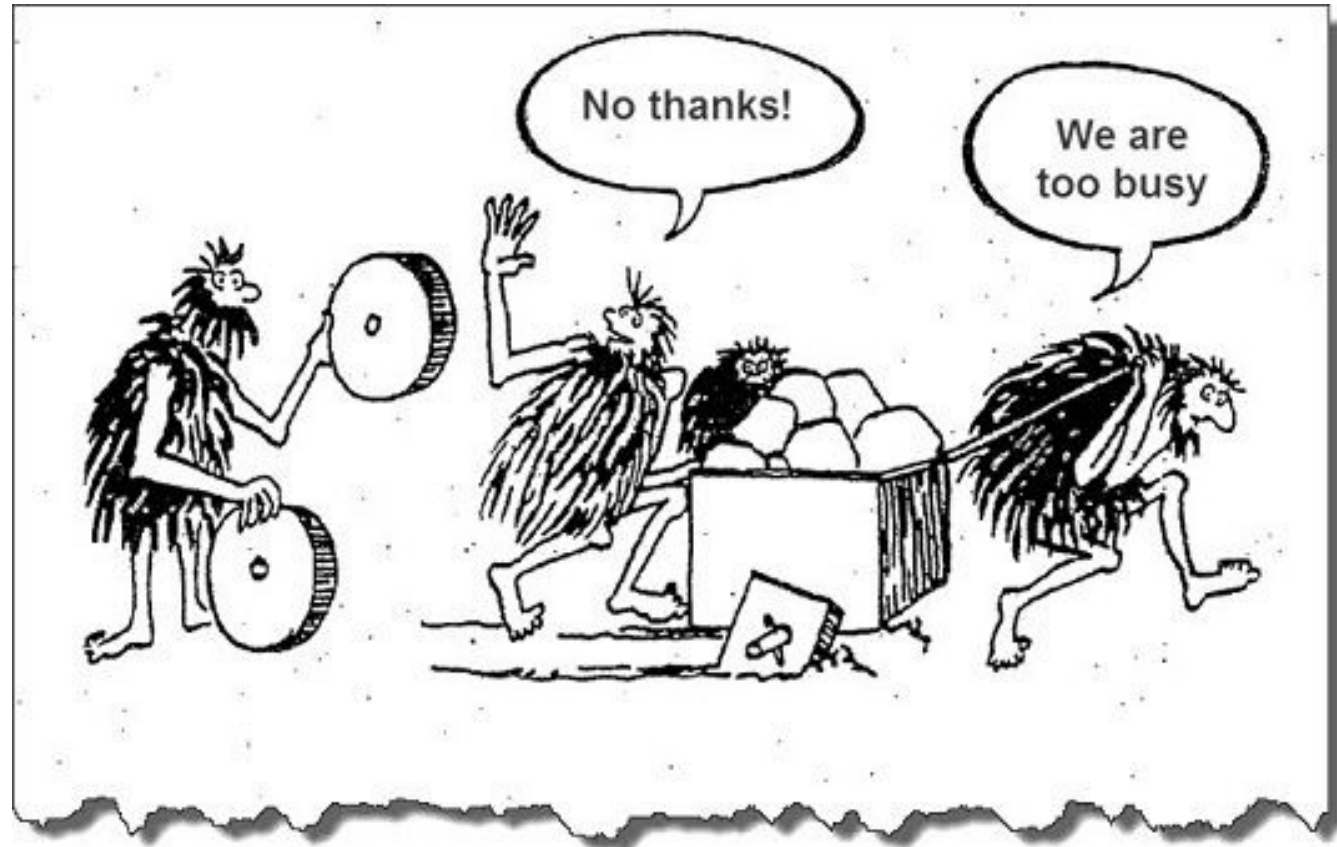
Why do People Resist Change?

A close-up photograph of a baby's face. The baby has a pouting expression, with its lips pressed together and slightly out. The eyes are looking upwards and to the sides. The skin is fair and smooth. The background is a plain, light color.

**Only wet babies likes to be
changed**

Why do People Resist Change?

- **Fear:** "Will the computer replace my job?"
- **Comfort:** "We have done it this way for 20 years, why change?«
- **No incentive :** « What do I gain in this project »
- **Lack of Time:** "I am too busy with my current work to learn a new tool.«
- ...



Change Management Models

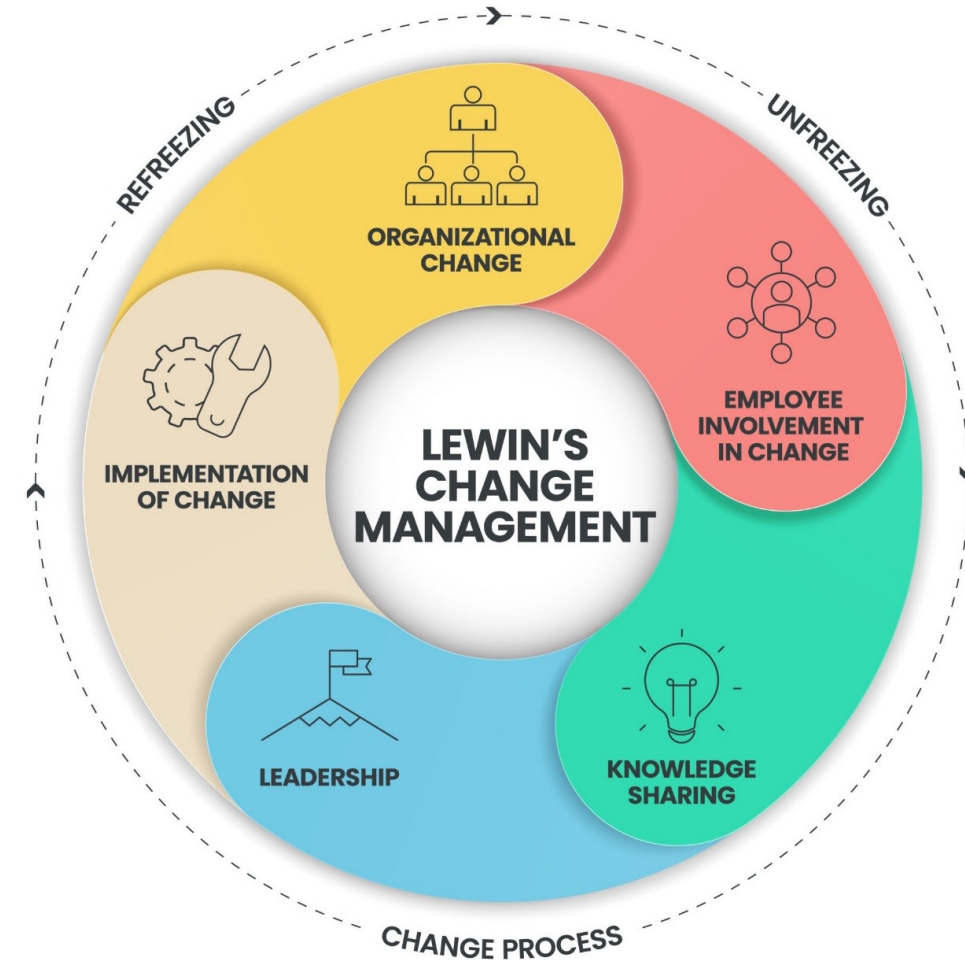
Lewin
Kotter

Introduction to Change Models

- Models are like "Maps." They help you know where you are in the journey.
- Two famous maps: **Lewin** (Simple) and **Kotter** (Detailed).

Lewin's Model Step 1: UNFREEZE

- **Goal:** Break the old habit.
- **Action:** Show people the "Crisis." Explain why staying the same is dangerous.
- **Example:** Show data that student enrollment is dropping because the registration process is too slow.



Lewin's Model Step 2: CHANGE

- **Goal:** The transition period.
- **Action:** Provide heavy support, training, and clear communication.
- **Note:** This is the most confusing and stressful time for staff.

Example: Weekly "Help Clinics" where staff can learn the new software together.

Lewin's Model - Step 3: REFREEZE

- **Goal:** Make it permanent.
- **Action:** Reward people who use the new system. Remove the old tools.

Example: The Rector announces that from now on, only digital reports will be accepted for annual reviews.

Kotter's 8 Steps - Part A: Create the Climate

1. **Urgency:** "We must change now!"
2. **Guiding Coalition:** Create a group of "influential" people (not just bosses).
3. **Vision:** A simple picture of the future.

Example: A vision of "A University where students can register directly from their phone."

: Kotter's 8 Steps - Part B: Engage & Enable

- 4. **Communicate:** Talk about the vision every day.
- 5. **Empower Action:** Remove the "Rules" that stop change.
- 6. **Short-term Wins:** Celebrate a small success after 1 month.
Example: Giving a "Digital Champion" award to the first department that goes 100% paperless.

Kotter's 8 Steps - Part C: Implement & Sustain

7. Don't Let Up: Use the first success to start bigger changes.

8. Make it Stick: Change the culture (habits).

Example: Integrating digital skills into the official Job Descriptions of all university staff.

Institutional vs. Cultural Change

- **Institutional (Hardware):** New Org-chart, new IT system, new Decree.
- **Cultural (Software):** Trust, collaboration, willingness to learn.
- **Key Lesson:** "Culture eats Strategy for breakfast." If the culture is bad, the strategy will fail.

ORGANIZATIONAL CULTURE IN CHANGE

The Change Leader's Iceberg



Case study : the Saigon Tech University

- Saigon Institute of Technology (SIT) is based on an institution, but the seminar case is a **fictionalized** teaching case designed for training purposes.

Preparation for Workshops

- In the workshop, you will:
 - Choose one real problem in your university.
 - Apply Lewin or Kotter to solve it.
 - Identify "Cultural Obstacles."
- **Ready to start?**

Workshop

How to

Guidelines

- 7 groups of 5 participants. Each group keeps the same composition across the four mornings.
- Each group should appoint :
 - one spokesperson,
 - one timekeeper,
 - and one laptop operator.
 - This reduces hesitation and improves execution speed.
- All outputs should be deposited in Google Classroom

Wooclap

- What is the main obstacle to digital transformation in your institution?
- Who usually resists the most when a digital change is introduced?
- What fails most often in institutional change: strategy, leadership, communication, or execution?
- Individually
- No guess